

**Political Portrayal of Women In Selected Nigerian Films:
A Feminist–Womanist Reading of *Ọlọlájùlọ* (Your Excellency) and *Lágídígba* (Royal
Bead)**

By

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Abstract

*The participation of women in politics has remained a central issue in feminist and womanist scholarship, particularly within African socio-cultural contexts where political power is historically gendered. Nigerian films, especially those produced in the Yorùbá language, often reflect and reinterpret social realities, including gender relations and political structures. This paper examines the political portrayal of women in two selected Nigerian films, *Ọlọlájùlọ* (Your Excellency) and *Lágídígba* (Royal Bead), through the theoretical lenses of feminism and womanism. While *Ọlọlájùlọ* presents a progressive image of women's political participation, emphasizing solidarity and electoral success, *Lágídígba* offers a contrasting narrative in which female-dominated political space becomes tyrannical and ultimately collapses due to gender exclusivity. Using qualitative evaluative film analysis, the study interrogates how political power, gender ideology, and symbolic representation are constructed. The analysis reveals that both films advocate complementary gender participation in political processes. They argue against both patriarchal exclusion and radical gender isolation, presenting instead a womanist vision of cooperative development. The study concludes that Nigerian films increasingly reflect contemporary debates on gender inclusion, leadership, and political equity.*

Keywords: Politics, political power struggle, political portrayals of women, feminism, womanism, Nollywood.

Introduction

Women's participation in politics has become a significant subject of scholarly discourse across disciplines such as political science, gender studies, sociology, and media studies. Globally, the underrepresentation of women in political leadership continues to generate debates on gender justice, democratic inclusion, and social development. In many African societies, including Nigeria, political power structures have historically been dominated by men, while women have been relegated to supportive or symbolic roles (Àiná, 2021; Yoon, 2022).

Despite constitutional provisions and global commitments to gender equality, women's political representation in Nigeria remains low. Reports show that women occupy less than 10 percent of elective political offices, reflecting deep-seated socio-cultural and institutional barriers (Inter-Parliamentary Union, 2023). Patriarchal norms, economic inequality, political violence, and limited access to resources continue to hinder women's participation in governance (Okeke-Ihejirika & Franceschet, 2022).

In response to these challenges, feminist and womanist scholars have advocated for increased female political participation and the dismantling of patriarchal power structures. Feminism emphasizes gender equality and the dismantling of male dominance, while womanism, an African-centered ideology, stresses cooperation between men and women for communal survival and progress (Nnaemeka, 2023; Kolawole, 2021).

Nigerian films, particularly Yoruba films, serve as important cultural texts that reflect societal values, political realities, and gender ideologies. Through narrative, symbolism, and characterization, films contribute to shaping public perceptions about women's roles in politics and leadership (Haynes, 2022; Adesokan, 2023).

This study examines the political portrayal of women in two selected Nigerian films, *Olólájàlò* and *Lágídígba*, with the aim of understanding how cinematic narratives reflect feminist and womanist arguments about gender, power, and political participation.

Literature Review

Women and Political Participation

The marginalization of women in political systems is a global phenomenon, but it is particularly pronounced in many African countries. Scholars have argued that cultural traditions, patriarchal institutions, and economic inequalities restrict women's access to political leadership (Aina, 2021; Bauer, 2022). In Nigeria, politics is often perceived as a masculine domain characterized by aggression, financial influence, and violence, making it difficult for women to participate effectively (Yoon, 2022).

Recent studies emphasize that increasing women's political representation leads to more inclusive governance and better social outcomes (O'Neil & Domingo, 2023). Women in leadership positions tend to prioritize issues such as education, healthcare, and social welfare, which contribute to national development.

Feminist Perspectives on Women in Politics

Feminist theory argues that gender inequality is structurally embedded in social and political institutions. Liberal feminists advocate equal opportunities and legal reforms, while radical feminists seek to dismantle patriarchal systems entirely (Hooks, 2021).

Contemporary feminist scholarship highlights the role of media in shaping gender norms and political identities. Films and television often reinforce stereotypes by portraying women as passive, emotional, or dependent, thereby discouraging political participation (Gill, 2022; Banet-Weiser, 2023).

However, recent African films have begun to challenge these narratives by presenting women as political actors, leaders, and agents of change (Adesokan, 2023).

Womanism and African Gender Ideology

Womanism emerged as a response to Western feminist frameworks that did not fully capture African women's experiences. Womanist scholars emphasize communal values, family structures, and gender complementarity (Kolawole, 2021).

Unlike radical feminism, which sometimes promotes gender separation, womanism stresses cooperation between men and women for societal progress (Nnaemeka, 2023). It recognizes the importance of both genders in maintaining social balance and political stability.

Recent studies suggest that African cultural productions, including films, increasingly reflect womanist ideals by portraying gender cooperation rather than antagonism (Oyèwùmí, 2024; Eze, 2022).

Political Representation of Women in Nigerian Films

Nollywood films have historically portrayed women within domestic and romantic contexts. However, recent productions increasingly explore themes of female leadership, political ambition, and social activism (Haynes, 2022).

Studies show that political films often reflect societal tensions around gender and power. Some films promote female empowerment, while others caution against radical gender exclusion (Adesọkan, 2023; Eze, 2022).

The symbolic use of objects, such as crowns, beads, or thrones, often signifies royalty, royal authority and gendered power structures in Yorùbá films (Ọ̀gúndélé, 2021).

Theoretical Framework: Feminism and Womanism

This study adopts feminism and womanism as complementary theoretical frameworks. Feminism provides the analytical tool for critiquing patriarchal exclusion and advocating gender equality. It explains the struggles faced by women in male-dominated political systems, as depicted in *Ọlólájùlọ*.

Womanism, on the other hand, emphasizes gender cooperation and communal harmony. It provides a useful framework for interpreting *Lágídígba*, where female political isolation leads to tyranny and societal collapse. The film ultimately promotes gender complementarity and power oppressive symbolism rather than exclusion.

Methodology

This study adopts a qualitative evaluative research design, which is appropriate for analyzing cultural texts such as films. The research is based on textual and narrative analysis of two selected Yoruba-language Nigerian films: *Ọlólájùlọ* (*Your Excellency*) and *Lágídígba* (*Royal Bead*). These films were purposively selected because they both address themes of political power, gender relations, and leadership, but from contrasting ideological perspectives.

The primary data for the study consist of the narrative content, character portrayals, dialogue, and symbolic elements present in the two films. The films serve as cultural texts that reflect socio-political realities and gender ideologies within Nigerian society.

Secondary data were obtained from scholarly books, journal articles, and recent studies published between 2021 and 2025 on feminism, womanism, political participation, and gender representation in African cinema. These sources provided the theoretical and conceptual

foundations for the analysis.

The method of analysis is qualitative and interpretive. The films were viewed repeatedly to identify major themes, character dynamics, political ideologies, and symbolic representations. Particular attention was paid to the roles assigned to female characters, their access to political power, and the consequences of their leadership.

The analysis is evaluative in nature, as it examines how the films construct political narratives about women and how these narratives align with feminist and womanist theoretical perspectives. The study also interprets symbolic elements, such as the royal bead in *Lágídígba*, as metaphors for gendered authority and exclusive power structures.

Film Analysis

Political Struggle and Female Solidarity in *Ọlólájùlọ*

Ọlólájùlọ presents a political contest between two parties: the male-dominated CPN with women participation and the inclusive Progressive Mothers Party. The film portrays Mrs. Adébóyè as a determined female candidate who challenges patriarchal political structures.

Her eventual victory is attributed to women's solidarity and collective political consciousness. The film reflects feminist ideals by emphasizing women's capacity for leadership, mobilization and political organization.

The attempted abduction of her son by her opponent symbolizes the structural obstacles and intimidation tactics often faced by female politicians which worked for her advantage by getting her sympathy and solidarity votes to defeat male contestant. Gender Isolation and Tyranny in the film *Lágídígba*.

Lágídígba presents a contrasting narrative. The protagonist, Jádésólá, establishes an all-female town after acquiring supernatural powers. The royal bead, "Lágídígba," symbolizes exclusive female authority, political control, and oppressive power. A kind of an authoritarian female political hegemony lording it over other women.

Initially, the town appears as a feminist utopia. However, Jádésólá's leadership becomes tyrannical and dictatorial illustrating the dangers of absolute power concentration and gender isolation. The eventual collapse of the *Lágídígba* town suggests that a society built on gender exclusion is unsustainable.

Fábunmi's call for women to return to their matrimonial home and cooperative family, and social structures reflects womanist ideology, emphasizing and recognising balance of power and gender partnership.

Discussion

Both films present contrasting visions of women's political power. *Ọlólájùlọ* supports feminist arguments for female inclusion and leadership, while *Lágídígba* critiques radical gender isolation and discrimination and marginalisation even in a world where women dominate and rule themselves. They suffer marginalisation and exclusion they accuse male

gender of entrenching and practising against womenfolks which indicates that power corrupts and absolute power corrupts absolutely no matter the gender power holder.

Together, the films promote a womanist conclusion which is suggestive of the fact that political systems function best when both men and women participate equally, cooperatively. The films show a kind of parallel discrimination in both patriarchal and matriarchal kingdoms.

Conclusion

The analysis demonstrates that Nigerian films serve as important cultural texts for negotiating gender and political ideologies. While feminist ideals of female empowerment are evident, the films ultimately endorse a womanist vision of gender complementarity, partnership and cooperativeness in power structure and exercise.

The study therefore concludes that sustainable political development requires the cooperation of both genders as equal partners in governance.

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